

A SHORT GUIDE TO THE SOLAR SYSTEM

The solar system is the Sun and everything bound to it by gravity: eight planets, their moons, dwarf planets, asteroids, and comets. This guide gives you one friendly page on each of the more famous members.

THE SUN

The Sun is a star at the center of the solar system. It is a huge ball of hot plasma, and its gravity holds every planet in orbit. It provides the light and heat that make life on Earth possible.

MARS -- THE RED PLANET

Mars is the fourth planet from the Sun. It looks red because its soil is rich in iron oxide, which is basically rust. Mars has two tiny moons, Phobos and Deimos, and the tallest volcano in the solar system, Olympus Mons. A day on Mars is about 24 hours and 39 minutes, close to Earth's.

JUPITER -- THE GIANT

Jupiter is the largest planet in the solar system, so big that all the other planets could fit inside it. Its most famous feature is the Great Red Spot, a storm wider than Earth that has raged for centuries. Jupiter has 95 confirmed moons, including Ganymede, the largest moon in the solar system.

SATURN -- THE RINGED PLANET

Saturn is best known for its bright rings, which are made of countless chunks of ice and rock. It is the second-largest planet. Saturn is a gas giant with no solid surface, and it is so light for its size that it would float in water if you could find a big enough bathtub.